

Learning to read braille may be replaced by smartphone app

By Tribune Content Agency, adapted by Newsela staff on 09.25.18

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A child who is blind touches braille during a Chinese class at the Chongqing School for the Blind. Photo: China Photos/Getty Images

PHILADELPHIA, Pennsylvania — On a recent morning, six visually impaired people gathered in a building in Philadelphia's Center City neighborhood. They huddled over their iPhones, waiting for Andrew Godwin's class to begin. The day's lesson? Creating and finding contacts in your cellphone.

They were at the Associated Services for the Blind and Visually Impaired center. It is called ASB for short. People who are blind and visually impaired can learn important skills there. These are skills people need to succeed in today's digital society. Everybody uses technology like phones and computers to talk to each other.

1 In 10 Children Can Read Braille

The nonprofit also offers classes in how to read braille. It is a system of raised dots that can be read with the fingers by people who are blind. For decades, ASB has been one of the largest U.S. producers of braille products. However, the number of braille readers has dropped sharply in the last 50 years.

In 1960, half of all legally blind children in the U.S. could read braille, according to the American Foundation for the Blind. Today, fewer than 1 in 10 people who are blind have that skill. The number of fluent braille readers has dropped for many reasons. Not having enough braille teachers is one reason, the increasing use of assistive technology is another.

"Technology offers the opportunity for those that are blind or visually impaired to live independently," said Godwin, 46.

App A New Tool For The Visually Impaired

To show what he means, Godwin opened an app, SeeingAI, on his iPhone and turned the camera to face himself. The phone described aloud what it saw. A "56-year-old male with dark hair, looking happy." Godwin laughed. The app thought he was 10 years older than he is.

The app isn't perfect, but it is helpful. Users can program it to recognize faces. Simply by holding up the camera, they can find out who is in the room without having to ask. Godwin is blind due to a rare genetic eye disease. When something is genetic, it is passed on in a family. He began teaching at ASB two years ago. Godwin hosts group classes on cellphone use as well as one-on-one computer lessons. He tailors the courses to the specific needs of his students. This includes an author who became blind, but wants to continue with his career.

Audiobooks and screen readers — programs that convert onscreen text into spoken speech — make reading faster for people like Godwin. They are used to relying on their hearing. They can also understand speech at a faster speed, compared to a normal speed.

Technology Won't Completely Replace Braille

However, the new technology is not welcomed by people like 87-year-old Lavera Diggins. She lost her sight when she was 18 and says the loss was "like death." Reading braille allowed her to find independence. After learning to read braille at ASB, she became a volunteer teacher. She creates braille labels for her clothing, cans and cassettes at home to identify the products on her own. Diggins doesn't expect to pick up new technology because of her age, and with braille, "once you have it, you can use it."

Also, braille lets people process information at their own pace.

"It's one thing to receive information passively as you're listening, but when you're bringing it in and interpreting it, it's much more of an active way of engagement," said Tony Stephens. He is director of advocacy and governmental affairs of the American Council of the Blind.

Technology offers alternatives to braille, he said, but it also makes access to braille easier. Refreshable braille displays, tablets with different braille texts, are becoming more affordable. Braille texts are big. Just one Harry Potter novel in braille fills a bookshelf. People who once stayed away for that reason can now carry a Harry Potter book in one hand.

Monica Heap, 65, is a sighted braille instructor who recently retired. She taught hundreds of students at ASB, and she believes the skill is crucial.

"Braille is like a paper and a pencil," said Heap. "What do you do when all of a sudden you don't have access to the Internet?"

Godwin doesn't read braille other than on short labels and notes around his house. His 9-year-old son, Andrew, who was born with the same eye disease, is a big braille reader. Andrew wants to be an engineer. He says it's important to read design plans and diagrams independently.

Still, in Godwin's classes, a future without braille seems possible. On that particular morning, cellphones spoke quiet commands to their users. Godwin sent a text to his wife using Apple's talk-to-text feature. He listened as his emails were read aloud and then used an app to read something from a printed document in front of him.

Together, Godwin and his students worked through the students' technological challenges.

"I love learning with you guys," Godwin said. "There's never a class of students that doesn't make my brain work hard."

Write Prompt

Write a short paragraph that explains the central idea of the article. Use at least two details from the article to support your response.

Quiz

- 1 What is MOST likely the reason the author included the quotes from Diggins, Stephens and Heap?
- (A) to highlight people who have benefited from the new technology that helps teach braille
 - (B) to show that few people use and teach braille currently and that people might stop using it altogether
 - (C) to prove that braille should be taught to everyone because technology may not last forever
 - (D) to provide opinions from people who feel that braille is still an important skill to learn

- 2 Which sentence from the article would be MOST important to include in a summary of the article?
- (A) On a recent morning, six visually impaired people gathered in a building in Philadelphia's Center City neighborhood.
 - (B) In 1960, half of all legally blind children in the U.S. could read braille, according to the American Foundation for the Blind.
 - (C) She creates braille labels for her clothing, cans and cassettes at home to identify the products on her own.
 - (D) Technology offers alternatives to braille, he said, but it also makes access to braille easier.

- 3 Read the following sentence from the article.

Not having enough braille teachers is one reason, the increasing use of assistive technology is another.

HOW does this detail develop the author's CENTRAL idea?

- (A) It provides examples of the different types of technology that have replaced braille.
 - (B) It shows that more people who are visually impaired feel independent because of technology.
 - (C) It highlights the main reasons behind the decrease in the number of braille readers.
 - (D) It demonstrates the ways in which technology is helping people learn to read braille.
- 4 Which answer choice accurately characterizes Godwin's reaction to technology for the visually impaired?
- (A) He believes that it is key in helping people who are visually impaired to successfully live on their own.
 - (B) He believes that learning technology is important but not as important as learning braille.
 - (C) He thinks that technology should completely replace braille because there is no longer a use for it.
 - (D) He thinks that people who are visually impaired should be cautious about relying on technology.

Answer Key

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Power Words

- 1 Which word goes with "easy to reach"?
(A) document
(B) access
- 2 Which sentence is an example of the word "access"?
(A) The door to the store was closed, so Tony went back home.
(B) The door to the store was open, so Tony walked inside.
- 3 Which sentence is an example of the word "retired"?
(A) Mr. Diaz had been a firefighter for 25 years, and yesterday was his last day.
(B) Mr. Diaz has been a firefighter for 25 years, just like his father and brother.
- 4 Which word goes with "career is over"?
(A) access
(B) retired
- 5 Which word goes with "not expensive"?
(A) affordable
(B) crucial
- 6 Which sentence is an example of the word "affordable"?
(A) Erica could not find a dress to wear to the school dance.
(B) Erica was happy that the \$300 dress was on sale for \$25 today.
- 7 Which word goes with "matters a lot"?
(A) document
(B) crucial
- 8 Which sentence is an example of the word "crucial"?
(A) Before the storm, it was essential for us to leave our home and go to a safe place.
(B) Before the storm, we saw many dark clouds in the skies and felt the strong winds.
- 9 Which word goes with "a science report"?
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- 10 Which sentence is an example of the word "document"?
(A) Molly looked at the sheet of instructions for how to put the new desk together.
(B) Molly looked at her new desk and then put her laptop, pens and notebooks on it.

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